

Saffron in the treatment of patients with mild to moderate Alzheimer's disease: a 16-week, randomized and placebo-controlled trial.

WHAT IS KNOWN: Herbal medicines have been used in the treatment of behavioural and psychological symptoms of dementia but with variable response. *Crocus sativus* (saffron) may inhibit the aggregation and deposition of amyloid β in the human brain and may therefore be useful in Alzheimer's disease (AD). **OBJECTIVE:** The goal of this study was to assess the efficacy of saffron in the treatment of mild to moderate AD. **METHODS:** Forty-six patients with probable AD were screened for a 16-week, double-blind study of parallel groups of patients with mild to moderate AD. The psychometric measures, which included AD assessment scale-cognitive subscale (ADAS-cog), and clinical dementia rating scale-sums of boxes, were performed to monitor the global cognitive and clinical profiles of the patients. Patients were randomly assigned to receive capsule saffron 30 mg/day (15 mg twice per day) (Group A) or capsule placebo (two capsules per day) for a 16-week study. **RESULTS:** After 16 weeks, saffron produced a significantly better outcome on cognitive function than placebo (ADAS-cog: $F=4.12$, d.f.=1, $P=0.04$; CDR: $F=4.12$, d.f.=1, $P=0.04$). There were no significant differences in the two groups in terms of observed adverse events. **WHAT IS NEW AND CONCLUSION:** This double-blind, placebo-controlled study suggests that at least in the short-term, saffron is both safe and effective in mild to moderate AD. Larger confirmatory randomized controlled trials are called for.

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